

Behavioral Question Study Guide

Our interviews are rooted in behavioral interview questions which ask about past situations or challenges you've faced and how you handled them, using Leadership Principles to guide the discussion. We avoid brain teasers (e.g., "How many windows are in Manhattan?") as part of the interview process. We've researched this approach and have found that those types of questions are unreliable when it comes to predicting a candidate's success at Amazon.

To learn more about our Leadership Principles, [click here](#).

Here are some examples of behavioral interview questions:

- Tell me about a time when you were faced with a problem that had a number of possible solutions. What was the problem and how did you determine the course of action? What was the outcome of that choice?
- When did you take a risk, make a mistake, or fail? How did you respond, and how did you grow from that experience?
- Describe a time you took the lead on a project.
- What did you do when you needed to motivate a group of individuals or promote collaboration on a particular project?
- How have you leveraged data to develop a strategy?

Keep in mind, Amazon is a data-driven company. When you answer questions, your focus should be on the question asked, ensure your answer is well-structured and provide examples using metrics or data if applicable. Reference recent situations whenever possible.

What is STAR Format?

The STAR Format is a powerful tool for structuring your responses to behavioral interview questions. By outlining the **Situation, Task, Action, and Result** of your experience, it allows you to present concrete examples and demonstrate how your skills translate into successful outcomes.

Situation: Briefly describe the context and challenge you faced. Be specific about the situation and the stakes involved, not a generalized description of what you have done in the past. Be sure to give enough detail for the interviewer to understand. The more relevant the situation is to the job you're interviewing for, the better.

Task: Define your specific role and responsibilities within the situation. What were you expected to achieve?

Action: Detail the specific actions you took to address the challenge. Highlight your thought process, skills applied, and any initiative demonstrated. This might be tricky, but use "I" statements (not "we") when discussing your actions. The interviewer is interested in learning about YOU and your specific contributions.

Result: Quantify the positive outcome of your actions. Be specific. Did you meet or exceed expectations? How did your actions impact the situation? Results may include:

- Cost savings and revenue generation
- Quantifying volume, size, and scale
- Week over week performance improvements (Or, month or year)
- Time to market, implementation time, time savings
- Customer or team impact
- Specific quality improvements

How to Prepare

1. Download and print the STAR Format Worksheet (Page 3) and Self-Assessment Rubric (Page 4).
2. Use the STAR Format Worksheet to structure your responses to behavioral questions (see Page 1 for sample questions).
3. Practice your responses out loud to refine your delivery and build confidence. Consider recording yourself to assess later.
4. Complete the Self-Assessment Rubric to gain insights into your strengths and areas for improvement. This will help you tailor your preparation and address any potential weaknesses.

Note: *These worksheets are designed to help you prepare for your interview based on my experience and understanding of effective interview techniques. It's important to remember that they are not official Amazon guidelines and you should consider tailoring your preparation accordingly.*

STAR Format Worksheet

S	Situation Describe the situation faced and the context of the story Where did this occur, when did it happen, why is it important? Consider including: Why is this important? What was the goal? What were the risks and potential consequences if nothing happened? Why did you choose this story to illustrate a xyz accomplishment?	Notes:
T	Task Define your specific role and responsibilities within the situation. Consider including: What were you expected to achieve? What was the goal? What did you do specifically versus the team? Why is your task important?	Notes:
A	Action What did you contribute, how did you do it, who else was involved? Consider Including: What were the most significant obstacles you faced? What trade-offs did you have to make? How did you set priorities and get team or manager buy-in?	Notes:
R	Result How did you measure success for this project? Consider including: Cost savings and revenue generation Quantifying customer or team impact in volume, size, and scale Week over week performance improvements (Or, month or year) Time to market, implementation time, time savings What were the lessons learned? What would you have done differently? How would you implement this at AWS?	Notes:

Self-Assessment Rubric

Soft Skills	No	Yes
Did I speak with enthusiasm and confidence?		
Did I sound angry, bored, disinterested, or arrogant?		
Did I speak at a reasonable pace and articulate my words clearly?		

Behavioral Questions	No	Yes
Were my responses concise (2-4 min)?		
Were my responses relevant to the role?		
Did I ramble or get off topic?		
Were my responses current (within 5 years)?		
Did I answer the question completely?		

Which of the Leadership Principles did my response demonstrate? <i>Aim for 4-6 per response.</i>	No	Yes
Customer Obsession		
Ownership		
Invent and Simplify		
Are Right, A Lot		
Learn and Be Curious		
Hire and Develop the Best		
Insist on Highest Standards		
Think Big		
Bias for Action		
Frugality		
Earn Trust		
Dive Deep		
Have Backbone; Disagree and Commit		
Deliver Results		
Strive to be Earth's Best Employer		
Success and Scale Bring Broad Responsibility		

Live Coding <i>(If applicable)</i>	No	Yes
Did I ask questions to thoroughly understand the problem?		
Did I identify and prioritize the customer?		
Did I explain my thought process during coding?		
Did I explain the trade-offs I considered along the way?		
Did I spend time at the end debugging and correcting my code?		
Did I test corner cases?		
Did I take hints when provided and demonstrate my coachability?		

Questions for the interviewer	No	Yes
Did I ask thoughtful questions regarding the team or products?		
Did I ask questions with answers that are easily found on the website or product page?		

Overall, is it clear I...	No	Yes
Make good decisions in the face of ambiguity or uncertainty?		
Am willing to make small progress toward a solution rather than finding the perfect solution right away?		
Take actions guided by customer input?		
Meet deadlines? Or am honest, open, and resilient when I don't?		
Investigate and get details in order to solve a problem?		
Build positive working relationships?		
Disagree thoughtfully by using data to explain my approach?		
Invest in the growth of others?		
Build systems that are scalable and serve customer needs?		
Generate new ideas for solving problems?		
Seek and embrace feedback from others?		
Take responsibility for mistakes?		
Identify ways to overcome conscious or unconscious bias?		
Actively listen and find ways to contribute?		

